

UNIT 12 Helicopter Rescue

The Marina has unloaded its cargo in the port of Gdynia, and is now in the Gulf of Finland passing south of Hanko well on her way towards her destination, the port of Kotka. Suddenly Captain James receives some alarming information from the engine room. Peter Green, one of the motormen, has injured his leg badly and needs immediate medical attention. The patient needs helicopter assistance and must be hoisted by helicopter stretcher.

Captain James then sends the following urgency message by DSC. He sends the message directly to the MRSC (Maritime Rescue Sub Centre) Helsinki, MMSI number 002302000, as the vessel is within its area.

Format: SELECTIVE
Party ID: 002302000
Category: URGENCY
Telecom 1: TELEPHONY
Work Channel: NONE
Transmitted: Ch 70

Marina receives the following acknowledgement by DSC:

Format: SELECTIVE
From:
Category: URGENCY
Telecom 1: TELEPHONY
Work Channel: 14
Transmitted: Ch 70

After this follows voice communication. Captain James picks up the radiotelephone and sends the following urgency message on channel 14:

Pan-Pan, Pan-Pan, Pan-Pan.

Rescue Centre Helsinki.

This is Marina, Marina, Marina.

Mike Whiskey Yankee Alpha 3

Position: Latitude 59° 40' North

Longitude 024° 00' East

One crew member badly injured.

REQUEST: Immediate helicopter assistance for transportation to hospital.

Over.

A few moments later there is an answer to the Pan-Pan and the following message is heard:

Pan-Pan, Marina.

This is Rescue Centre Helsinki.

Pan-Pan received.

Marina.

Rescue Centre Helsinki.

We are coming to your assistance.

We are sending a helicopter and doctor.

Say again your position.

Over.

Rescue Centre Helsinki.

Marina

Position: Latitude 59° 40' North

Longitude 024° 00' East

Over.

Marina.

Rescue Centre Helsinki.

Understood.

Helicopter ETA is 30 minutes.

What is your course and speed and what are the weather conditions in area?

Over.

Rescue Centre Helsinki.

Marina.

Our course is 090°, speed 15 knots. Southwesterly wind 8 m/s, visibility 3 miles.

Over.

Rescue Centre Helsinki asks the Marina to stand by on traffic channel 14. It will take about 30 minutes before the helicopter can take off, and another 30 minutes for it to



Education and Culture

Leonardo da Vinci

reach the scene of the accident. Meanwhile the patient is being prepared for hoisting. Peter Green, the injured man, has been given first aid and a life-jacket has been put on. He is given pain-relievers, and information about his medication is tagged on to his person. As Peter is in foreign waters, his seaman's book is also sent along with him.

All loose parts in the rigging must be taken down and secured before the helicopter arrives. The helicopter will normally approach the ship from the stern on the port side. This gives the winch-operator and the pilot the best view of the ship. The vessel must maintain a steady course and a constant speed. It is essential that the crew has been briefed, and know exactly what to do, and that all preparations have been completed before the helicopter arrives. Voice communication will be impossible when the air is filled with the powerful noise of engines and rotor-blades. The air will be white with spray; and it will even be difficult to stand upright.

As it is dark outside, the ship has to be well illuminated to make it easier for the helicopter to see the vessel and the pick-up area. Captain James gives an order to direct the spotlights towards the deck, so as not to blind the pilot.

The helicopter is now only a few miles from the Marina.

Marina.

This is helicopter pilot.

We are now 2 miles from your position.

Maintain a course 245° that will keep the wind 30° on port bow. We will first lower the guide rope.

Then a stretcher in order to pick up the patient.

Over.

Helicopter.

This is Marina.

Understood.

I will keep wind 30° on port bow.

Landing party ready to receive you.

Over.



Education and Culture

Leonardo da Vinci

The guide rope is lowered, touches the water and lands on deck. It is tended by one of the deckhands throughout the operation. The helicopter takes a hovering position a little away from the ship on the port side, and a rescue man is lowered. He will take charge of the hoisting operation. Next the helicopter stretcher is lowered. Peter Green is moved to the helicopter stretcher and he is covered in blankets, which are secured so as not to blow away during the lift. The rescue man gives the signal for hoisting. Slowly and rather awkwardly the stretcher rises into the air, while the men are trying to steady it with the guide-rope. The stretcher finally reaches the helicopter, where the winch-operator is ready to receive it.

The operation has been carried out successfully. The rescue man is hoisted, and the helicopter rushes to the nearest hospital, where Peter will be given medical treatment. On board the Marina there is a feeling of relief and the vessel continues on its voyage under the dark September sky.